



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Theory Report

2024 Stage 2 MW Exam

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Theory Exam Chair Report, Beverley Blanning MW

The examiners have noted that this year's report covers much of the same ground as in previous years, so much of what follows may sound rather familiar. Nevertheless, candidates are advised to study this and earlier examiners' reports in order to understand the same areas of weakness that repeatedly lead to a fail result in the theory examination, regardless of the questions set.

Recurring themes include a failure to answer the question asked and a lack of the critical analysis needed to provide an MW-level answer. As in previous years, we observed many students who seem unable to use examples to support the points they are making. Very often, we see instead a simple reporting (and sometimes blind acceptance) of what somebody has told them, rather than analysis or application of this information to the question at hand. We also see the same examples repeated across questions and papers, which suggests insufficient experience and depth of preparation for this part of the MW exam.

The theory exam requires candidates to have both breadth and depth of knowledge, and to be able to apply this learning to specific questions, under time pressure, to show clear understanding of the global world of wine. Do not underestimate the challenge. We are looking for candidates to demonstrate mastery, which means you need to show

- a) that you understand the material you are writing about;
- b) that you realise there are usually several ways of looking at a question; and
- c) that you can weigh up the pros and cons of an issue and come to your own, informed conclusions.

All of this goes beyond merely describing what winemaker X says or does. Before writing, ask yourself: How is this relevant? Does this answer the question? Have I considered all aspects of this question? Resist the temptation to insert your favourite examples where they are not relevant. Remember that examples will frequently be enhanced by comparisons to alternative points of view from other sources.

The examiners have commented on a general decline in the standard of answers this year across all papers, which is reflected in a lower overall pass rate compared to last year of 21%. There did appear to be a higher than usual number of particularly ill-prepared candidates this year, with some answering the wrong number of questions across multiple papers, or failing to turn up to one or more papers, resulting in some very low marks. Although we had fewer candidates failing all papers this year, a surprising number scored marks low enough to lose a future attempt at the examination.

As well as studying the reports of the paper chairs that follow, prospective candidates are advised to be clear on the content of the syllabus for each paper and to practice writing essays to time. As seen in previous years, some candidates appear to arrive in the exam room with pre-prepared essays in their heads which they struggled to adapt to the specific questions with which they were faced. A preferable revision tactic might be to research and learn an area of the syllabus and then practice answering essay questions unseen, under exam conditions.

Finally, on a more positive note there were, as always, some excellent candidates who ably demonstrated the mastery required to achieve a pass. The theory examination is a challenge, but with the right approach and preparation it is quite possible to succeed.

Paper one report 2024: Paper chair, Rhys Pender MW

General Comments

There tends to be a repeat of the same issues that prove to be stumbling blocks for passing paper 1. The key areas that were a challenge in the 2024 exam were based around not properly answering the question, and in many cases just throwing in lots of examples describing what someone does without any analysis around it.

There were a lot of papers submitted that seemed overly focused on examples, at the cost of insight and analysis. In the effort to fit in as many global examples as possible, candidates neglected to analyse those examples and give their own insight. Examples should be used to build or support an opinion or argument, and candidates should look at the pros and cons associated with the examples used, not merely drop them in. Demonstrating this critical thinking is a key requirement for passing the exam.

For several questions, it also seemed like most students were all using the same examples. If all your examples come from a student seminar or student trip, then it is hard to show individual insight and thought. It is a good idea to try to seek out alternative examples yourself to expand your repertoire of options to use in essays.

Using examples from all corners and price and quality levels of the wine world is also an essential part of the exam. It comes across in some essays that students are only thinking about classic regions and high-end wines, rather than demonstrating global knowledge in all levels of the wine industry.

A couple of the questions in this exam also exposed the lack of knowledge of some candidates, with essays demonstrating only a superficial understanding of paper 1 topics.

1. How can vineyard practices minimise the need for must adjustments in the winery? [Note: answers may cover the syllabuses of papers 1 and 2]

It was important to consider many areas of vineyard management for this question, and this was often the difference between a pass or fail. Some candidates listed only a few practices and linked them suitably to the need for must adjustments, but left out far too many important areas of vineyard work that should have been considered. Many who were unsuccessful were unable to demonstrate in their essay a deep enough understanding of how viticulture can be used as a tool in shaping must and wine.

A number of students ended up writing essays on must adjustments and additives without linking to vineyard practices. This question also seemed to expose some weakness in knowledge of the nuances of vineyard practices as evidenced by misconceptions, misunderstandings and over generalisations. The best essays considered a wide range of vineyard activities, defined the key must adjustments and linked the two together showing an interesting range of examples to support their position.

2. Does manual work in the vineyard deliver better quality wine than mechanised alternatives?

There were different approaches to answering this question, and more than a third of those who attempted it passed. The best papers considered both manual and mechanised alternatives and analysed the pros and cons of each with interesting examples along the way, clearly linking them to a well-defined idea of “better quality wine”. There were some interesting insights into some of the very creative and advanced technologies being trialled in vineyard mechanisation.

The unsuccessful papers either didn't arrive at any conclusion, were overly one-sided towards manual work without considering benefits of mechanisation, or didn't explain sufficiently well the link to better quality wine. Many seemed to read the question as manual versus machine harvesting to the exclusion of other vineyard work.

Being practical in the pros and cons of each rather than dogmatic made for the most compelling papers. The reality of labour availability, cost and wine style and price needed to be considered. A common issue is candidates only looking through the lens of expensive wine where production costs aren't such an issue, rather than the reality of the greater wine world. There were some glaring oversimplifications and stereotyping of entire countries that showed a lack of global wine knowledge.

3. 'Controlling yields to maintain quality is no longer necessary.' Discuss.

This question required a well laid out definition of quality. It was important to look at quality from various perspectives, with less successful candidates limiting their scope. The best essays looked at different grape varieties, desired styles, scale of production, vine age, etc. There were some key areas that needed to be included such as legal controls on yield in some regions and also a historical perspective given the “no longer” wording of the question. The concept of balance and lower yields not always being better needed to be clearly explained with good examples.

The best candidates showed various scenarios where controlling for lower or higher yields was suitable for maintaining quality. Without a clear definition and layout, it was an easy question to start rambling on and, unfortunately, many essays did just that without any clear conclusions.

4. How can slopes in vineyards influence grape quality?

This was the most popular question on the exam. It is a relatively straightforward question. Answers needed to cover all the key influences of slopes, and to keep the discussion tightly linked to the influence of slopes on grape quality. Some candidates got sidetracked and focused more on the practicality of working on slopes, or the advantages and disadvantages of slopes to grape growers, rather than tying their answers closely to the effect on grape quality.

This question also highlighted a lack of depth of understanding of grape growing in many candidates' answers, where essays were similar to a WSET Level 3 standard rather than showing the analysis and depth of understanding for MW level. These essays merely mentioned a few basics such as sun, air drainage and aspect but didn't explore other areas such as soils, desired styles, water, disease, etc., and often in insufficient depth to display the insight required for a passing grade.

The best papers covered all the key relevant features of slopes with strong analysis in various scenarios, showing insight beyond the basics and demonstrating clearly their understanding. These were not just limited to slopes' ability to help ripening in cooler northern hemisphere climates, but also looked at everything from soil to desired wine style, with a broad range of supporting examples.

5. Assess the relative merits of high- and low-density planting in vineyards.

There was potentially lots to write about for this question, so an organised approach was needed. A good definition was required of low versus high density and then relevant examples covering different wine styles and quality levels were needed to make for a complete essay.

Some candidates listed many examples without sufficient discussion on the relative merits, therefore not properly addressing the question. On occasion, by simply listing examples of what people do without analysis, candidates ended up contradicting themselves. Many students seemed to use the same examples.

The best essays used examples from around the world for different scenarios, defined high versus low density well, considered things like history and tradition, climate, soils, water, vine age, equipment, vigour, yield, disease, wine style, quality, economics, and discussed not just what but also how and why.

6. 'It is better to have too few nutrients in vineyard soils than too many.' Discuss.

This was the least popular question on the paper 1 exam, perhaps seeming to have a more scientific slant. It was easy to get sidetracked into a long description listing different nutrients, what a vine needs and each nutrient's effect on the plant, but regurgitating information from a textbook didn't answer the question, which was looking instead for a discussion of which is better in each situation, too few or too many.

"Better" needed to be discussed and defined for the context of each situation – potentially linking to yield, style, health, wine type, price, ease of correction and cost.

The question also clearly talked about nutrients in "vineyard soils", so the discussion needed to start there and then focus on the key nutrients and the merits or challenges of too much or too little of each. A key area was discussing what you could do to correct the nutrient imbalance, as this would often lead to coming down with a considered opinion on which is better.

Paper two report 2024: Paper chair, Richard Kershaw MW

General Comments

After reviewing the examiner feedback for the 2024 paper 2 examination, several key themes emerged regarding overall candidate performance. A widening gap between candidates who excelled and those who struggled was evident despite the pass rate remaining similar to last year. Top candidates demonstrated practical, working knowledge, supporting their answers with appropriate and specific examples. In contrast, weaker candidates often relied on vague data, attempting to fill gaps with extraneous details or embellishments.

The key areas for improvement include: reading the question carefully, applying critical analysis, structuring essays logically, broadening knowledge, providing technical depth, and using examples effectively. Taking each in turn:

- **Reading the question:** Many candidates struggled to fully grasp the question's nuances, leading to incomplete answers. Failure to address all parts of the question was a common issue. Some candidates even answered only two questions or focused on one section, significantly hurting their passing chances.
- **Critical analysis:** A lack of critical analysis was a recurring concern. Many candidates stated facts without explaining the practical implications, particularly when using examples. Repetition of the same examples across multiple questions without providing relevant context was also common. Examiners stressed the need to link examples directly to the question.
- **Essay structure:** Candidates often struggled with logical structuring. Clear introductions, a progression of ideas, and concise conclusions were frequently missing. Definitions of key terms were either absent or poorly articulated, making it difficult for examiners to follow the argument. Defining and explaining terms early on is essential to anchor the discussion effectively. Errors of basic grammar, spelling, and punctuation could also hinder clarity.
- **Breadth of knowledge:** Many candidates displayed strong knowledge in certain areas but lacked a comprehensive understanding of the syllabus. Gaps were particularly evident in topics like fortified wines. Success requires a well-rounded grasp of all wine styles and techniques.
- **Technical depth:** Broad generalisations and unsupported statements were frequent issues. Candidates are expected to use specific figures, correct terminology, and detailed explanations of winemaking processes, including chemical and biological aspects. Accurate units of measurement are essential.
- **Use of practical examples:** Strong candidates applied their theoretical knowledge to real-world scenarios using specific examples from diverse regions and styles. Examiners emphasised that examples should support arguments, not serve as the foundation of the answer. Merely listing wineries or winemakers without explaining their relevance weakened responses.
- **Common pitfalls:** Recurring issues included overly descriptive answers, repetitive examples across questions, superficial content needing more technical depth, poor planning leading to unstructured responses, and over-reliance on personal anecdotes. While individual experiences can enrich an answer, they should not overshadow technical accuracy or replace factual content.

1. Why would a winemaker choose to filter wine, and what are the advantages and disadvantages of doing so?

This question gauged candidates' understanding of filtration as a vital winemaking process. It required them to go beyond listing advantages and disadvantages and demonstrate a nuanced understanding of why a winemaker might choose to filter, considering specific winemaking objectives.

More robust answers started with defining filtration and its purpose. It was important to outline the different filtration methods – earth filtration, pad filtration, membrane filtration, and crossflow filtration – highlighting their application at various winemaking stages. Candidates should have explored the advantages, such as improved clarity, enhanced stability, consistency across batches, and speed to market. Conversely, candidates should have critically evaluated potential drawbacks like the loss of sensory qualities, risks of oxygen exposure, and the cost and environmental impact

It was necessary to acknowledge the trade-off between achieving clarity and preserving a wine's character to do justice to the question. It would have been beneficial to know specifics on pore sizes for different filtration targets and their implications for microbial stability and sensory attributes. Finally, discussing alternatives like fining or cold stabilisation alongside recent innovations in filtration technology would have shown a comprehensive understanding.

This question was the most popular in Section A, with over two-thirds of candidates choosing it, likely because they saw it as more straightforward. However, many responses ended up poorly structured, lacking substance, or offering overly general descriptions of filtration without showing a clear understanding of its application. Consequently, the pass rate fell below the average.

While most candidates could identify some advantages and disadvantages, many lacked a more insightful understanding of the different filtration types and their specific applications, indicating gaps in technical knowledge. The discussion of pore sizes and their implications could often have been more detailed.

Few candidates explored the balance between filtration and sensory preservation. Many overlooked alternatives to filtration and gave limited attention to recent technological developments. Most answers focused too heavily on the advantages and disadvantages without fully addressing why a winemaker chooses to filter.

Some candidates generalised that wines that eschewed malolactic fermentation or contained residual sugar always require filtration, without considering alternatives. This suggests a limited perspective on filtration. There were also instances of candidates confusing stabilisation processes with filtration and expressing a dogmatic view of filtration as detrimental to wine quality. On a positive note, many candidates avoided a purely philosophical debate on filtration and acknowledged both sides. Some presented an excellent understanding of filtration, supported by technical details about filtration systems, their use, and the relationship between micron size and wine style. The better answers also considered the winemaker's intentions and the impact on results and provided convincing examples.

2. Discuss how and why acidity is adjusted in musts and wine.

This question tested candidates' grasp of acidity's importance in wine balance, flavour, stability, and ageing. It required a theoretical and practical understanding of acid adjustments across various wine styles and regions, including legal implications.

A comprehensive response would have outlined how acidity contributes to the wine's overall balance, flavour profile, microbial stability, and ageing capacity. The answer should have delineated the standard methods of acidity adjustment: adding tartaric, malic, or citric acid to elevate acidity and employing malolactic fermentation (MLF) or potassium bicarbonate/calcium carbonate to reduce it. The characteristics, implications, and typical use cases of each acid and method should have been discussed, along with the factors influencing these decisions: climate, desired wine style, grape variety, and regional wine laws. Candidates should also have specified techniques and optimal timing for acidity adjustments from must to pre-bottling stages.

The question seemed polarizing as many candidates demonstrated only a basic understanding of acidity adjustment, lacking depth, especially in explaining the "how" and "why". Despite these problems, this question had the second-highest pass rate. More robust scripts identified acid adjustments for stylistic purposes and explored acidity's influence on taste, microbial stability, and SO₂ efficiency, including pH's connection to Brettanomyces and MLF's role. They also identified the impact of climate on acidity.

For the remaining candidates, a deeper understanding of specific acids, their unique properties, and applications was needed. The ability to connect theory with real-world practice was crucial in this context.

Areas that were poorly addressed included deacidification, the crucial relationship between pH and acidity, technical insight (e.g., calculating tartaric acid's effect on pH), pH's impact on color and longevity, and the scope beyond red and white wines. The discussion of legal implications and regulations surrounding acidity adjustment was often superficial, lacking specific details.

3. What are the key factors for a winemaker to consider when choosing an appropriate fermentation vessel for wine production?

This question assessed candidates' understanding of the various types of fermentation vessels and how their characteristics influence the winemaking process and final product. It required candidates to focus on technical and stylistic considerations when selecting a suitable vessel for specific winemaking goals.

Strong answers defined fermentation vessels and explained their role in achieving the desired wine quality and style and the rationale behind selecting a specific type of vessel based on the intended outcome for the wine, considering both traditional practices and modern innovations in winemaking.

Candidates should have discussed the pros and cons of commonly used materials, such as stainless steel, oak, concrete, clay-based vessels, breathable plastic, and fibreglass, evaluating how the choice of vessel influences flavour, aroma, texture, and ageing potential. Also relevant to discuss were

vessel size and shape, temperature control, fermentation kinetics, logistical management, cleaning and maintenance, oxygen exposure, and cost.

Other areas for consideration were labour requirements and potential for automation, especially for tasks like cap management. Candidates might have explored the sustainability and longevity of different vessels, including their environmental impact, durability, and reuse potential.

This question was the second most popular, but the pass rate was the second lowest. Many candidates struggled with focus and planning, leading to answers that needed more structure and clarity. They often provided general descriptions of fermentation vessels without linking them adequately to their impact on wine style or the winemaking process. Most answers focused heavily on stainless steel and oak, often neglecting other materials, resulting in an incomplete evaluation of the full range of vessel options.

Stronger candidates effectively discussed how vessel material influences temperature control, oxygen exposure, and fermentation kinetics. These answers were well organised, addressing key winemaking stages about vessel choice, using varied examples, and balancing technical and stylistic considerations. Successful candidates also covered practical aspects such as ease of cleaning.

However, many answers were overly descriptive, with little explanation of the technical reasoning behind vessel choices or assessment of the chemical processes involved. Poorer responses often included simplistic definitions, vague statements, or incomplete examples, failing to demonstrate a deep understanding of the topic. Areas such as oxygen management or extraction methods were frequently overlooked or only superficially mentioned. Several candidates struggled with the proper use of abbreviations and referred to winemakers by their first names, detracting from their professionalism.

4. Compare and contrast the key production methods for the following fortified wines: aged Tawny Port; Bual Madeira; Marsala Superiore; Rutherglen Muscat.

This question was the least popular and had the lowest pass rate. It assessed candidates' knowledge of fortified wine production methods, emphasising how each stage—grape selection, harvest conditions, fermentation, fortification timing, spirit type, ageing, and blending—shapes the final product's sensory qualities and ageing potential. We expected candidates to go beyond basic descriptions and critically evaluate how regional differences and traditional practices shape the style and quality of these wines.

Strong answers methodically compared the production methods for each wine, linking specific techniques—such as barrel types, spirit additions, and ageing conditions—to their sensory outcomes. High-scoring answers incorporated relevant examples and data, including Baumé at picking, residual sugar (RS) levels, alcohol by volume (ABV), and ageing times, demonstrating a deep understanding of technical and sensory aspects.

Better candidates provided structured comparisons of the wines at each production stage, using detailed examples to explain how techniques impact the final wine. They demonstrated thorough knowledge, particularly in discussing climate and grape variety choices, which are crucial in fortified

wine production. These candidates often highlighted shared characteristics, such as the growth of all four wines in hot climates, and connected production methods to the wines' sensory qualities and ageing potential.

However, many candidates struggled, particularly with Marsala Superiore, often displaying incomplete or inaccurate knowledge of its sweetening methods or solera system. Weak answers needed more critical analysis, focusing too much on describing the wines rather than comparing their production methods. Some candidates failed to provide specific details on fermentation, fortification, or ageing, which undermined their ability to evaluate how these processes influence the final wine style. Common shortcomings included vague descriptions, particularly in explaining the solera system for Marsala and providing correct RS values. Furthermore, lower-scoring responses tended to be descriptive rather than analytical, offering little explanation of the technical reasoning behind winemaking choices or comparisons between the wines.

The best answers took a step-by-step approach, comparing production methods across the wines for each key stage (region/climate, grape type, fermentation, fortification, ageing). This structure allowed for more critical comparisons and thoughtful analysis, recognising both shared techniques and key differences. Candidates who excelled included specific data points (e.g., RS, ABV, ageing times), significantly strengthening their answers.

Overall, the examiners observed a clear gap in knowledge between candidates who had studied fortified wines in detail and those relying on general information. This question highlighted the importance of thorough preparation across all wine styles and should serve as a motivating factor for candidates to commit to their studies, as specific questions on lesser-known styles are likely to continue to appear in future examinations.

5. What is *Brettanomyces* and how can the factors that influence it be controlled?

This question assessed candidates' understanding of *Brettanomyces*, a yeast significantly impacting a wine's sensory profile. Candidates needed to demonstrate knowledge of the conditions promoting its growth and practical winemaking techniques to manage it. Examiners expected candidates to clearly define *Brettanomyces* as a yeast genus, referencing the volatile phenols it produces—particularly 4-ethylphenol (4-EP) and 4-ethylguaiacol (4-EG)—which create aromas like barnyard and medicinal notes. While Brett is commonly associated with red wines, candidates should have known that it can also affect white wines. Notably, the examiners expected candidates to include the characteristics and specific ways it can be considered to influence wine positively in small amounts for complexity and negatively when it dominates the sensory profile.

A strong response would have detailed how factors like residual sugar, pH (particularly above 3.6), fermentation temperature, and oxygen presence encourage *Brettanomyces* growth.

Candidates should have included practical winemaking solutions, such as sanitation practices, adjustments to wine composition (managing pH, sugar, and alcohol), barrel management, and treatments like sulphur dioxide (SO₂), filtration, or chemical interventions like chitosan. Instead of relying on generalisations, answers were expected to offer specific examples and technical values demonstrating effective *Brettanomyces* management.

While most candidates demonstrated a basic understanding of Brett, many struggled with technical depth and practical insight. Common issues included focusing on reactive measures like SO₂ additions without discussing proactive strategies such as sanitation or oxygen management. Many answers needed more detailed explanations of how these methods work, with candidates offering inconsistent values for pH control and insufficient discussion of the role of oxygen in Brett's development. Additionally, few candidates mentioned early detection methods like sensory and lab analysis, which are crucial in managing Brett before it causes significant spoilage.

Many candidates mentioned barrel hygiene, but they often lacked detail and rarely explored techniques like ozone or advanced barrel sanitation. They also frequently overlooked filtration, a critical method for removing Brett cells before bottling.

More robust responses provided practical winemaking insight, explaining specific strategies like controlling fermentation temperatures or using reverse osmosis to prevent or mitigate Brett. These candidates also showed a comprehensive understanding of both proactive and reactive approaches, balancing sanitation, detection, and treatment methods with accurate technical values.

Candidates needed to provide practical examples from winemaking and discuss proactive and reactive strategies. Detailed analysis of oxygen's role, barrel management, filtration methods, and consistent values for control factors like pH led to more substantial, convincing answers.

6. Blending is a useful tool in winemaking. Discuss how, and in what circumstances, a winemaker would choose to employ it.

This question assessed understanding of blending as both a corrective measure and a strategic tool in winemaking. The examiners expected candidates to thoroughly discuss the objectives of blending, decision-making processes, and practical outcomes. Winemakers use blending reactively to solve winemaking challenges and proactively to create wines with specific characteristics such as balance, complexity, and consistency. Candidates needed to explore blending approaches, such as varietal combinations, vineyard selections, and barrel management techniques, explaining how winemakers apply these methods in different contexts.

The more robust responses clearly defined the purpose of blending—enhancing balance, increasing complexity, adjusting sensory attributes (aroma, flavour, texture), and ensuring consistency across vintages. High-scoring candidates moved beyond general statements, using specific examples to illustrate how blending addresses challenges like vintage variation and elevating wine quality, particularly in large-scale commercial production. They also discussed how legal or regulatory requirements influence blending decisions, with examples like non-vintage Champagne or the solera system used in Sherry.

While some candidates performed well, many struggled to move beyond a descriptive approach. A common issue was superficial discussions of blending techniques without fully explaining the "how" and "why" behind their use. For instance, candidates would mention Bordeaux varietal blending or Champagne blending for consistency without exploring the strategic reasons or the techniques

employed. Additionally, many focused too much on premium wine production, neglecting blending's crucial role in large-scale commercial winemaking, where consistency and efficiency are key.

Another area where candidates often fell short was the practical details of blending. Essays frequently needed more discussions on how winemakers conduct blending trials, taste and analyse components, and benchmark their blends against competitors or market demands. Few mentioned the role of sensory and laboratory analysis or the process of adjusting blends to meet stylistic or commercial goals. Additionally, the blending of oak types and its influence on the final product was often overlooked, despite being an important aspect of barrel management. Incorporating these practical details would have shown enhanced understanding of the blending process.

While most candidates demonstrated a basic understanding of blending, many needed more technical depth and required better organisation. Several candidates dived into their responses without defining the scope or arranging their points logically, resulting in meandering answers. Others neglected critical areas, such as regulatory considerations or the practical steps involved in large-scale blending. A structured approach is essential to delivering a comprehensive and well-organised response.

Strong responses combined theoretical knowledge with practical insight, covering a range of winemaking contexts and offering detailed explanations of the decision-making process. Future candidates should focus on clearly explaining the 'how' and 'why' of blending, incorporating practical steps like conducting trials and addressing market demands while ensuring a well-structured, in-depth response.

Paper three report 2024: Paper chair, Caroline Gilby MW

General comments

Paper 3 is a technical paper that tests understanding of how a wine gets from the end of fermentation to the consumer in good and legal condition. The questions are intended to test how candidates can apply their knowledge to scenarios in the real world of wine handling rather than simply repeating learned facts.

The paper does require factual detail with numbers, measurements, and correct units. It also requires knowledge about laws that apply in terms of additives, processing aids, labelling and packaging, particularly in major markets such as the European Union (EU). This is not an easy topic to learn from textbooks, nor on standard winery tours, so it is strongly recommended that candidates find some time to visit 'backstage' at wineries, labs, and bottling lines to understand how processes work in practice, and this is a useful way of gathering material for use as examples too. Candidates need to physically visit wineries, observe firsthand winemaking activities through the entire process and ask all the questions they can to fully understand how wines are made and equipment is used, as well as factors problems that may arise and what the winemaker or quality control manager does to address such situations.

In 2024, strong candidates demonstrated appropriate technical knowledge, supported by real world evidence and examples. Examples are clearly a problem for some candidates on this paper, but it really does not add anything useful to talk about classed growth claret or top burgundy in a question on bag in box. Examples should also be there to support and validate arguments rather than being simple statements of 'x does y'. Too many candidates continue to be unaware of basic technical information such as typical free SO₂ levels, using vague terms like "sufficient SO₂". They also need to know legal limits on total SO₂ by style. Some proof reading is required too - there were a few giving SO₂ in grammes per litre. Unfortunately, such mistakes undermine confidence in everything a candidate has written.

Key knowledge for MW candidates bears repeating: EU limits for SO₂ use and units (including organic wines) and clarity about whether referring to total or free SO₂; typical levels of free SO₂ for various styles; molecular SO₂ and pH; limits for volatile acidity; common wine additives and processing aids and what they do (with legal limits and typical usage levels); pore sizes for filtration, and so on. Inaccurate use of "sulphur" instead of sulphites or sulphur dioxide was much less of a problem this year, though it still cropped up.

As ever candidates do need to read the question carefully and answer what has been asked. Many answers are purely descriptive and fail to apply knowledge in the context of the question. Many of the answers clearly come from a textbook or seminar, giving a bit of an understanding but not the full picture. It's important that candidates can apply relevant points but tie those into discussion and analysis, supported by examples.

1. What are the risks of storing wine in wooden barrels and how can they be mitigated?

This should have been a straightforward question to answer, and it did result in the highest pass rate of the paper. Examiners were looking for clear understanding that barrel use in this context is mainly about storage, and not about adding flavour or influencing style (though excess wood influence would be a valid risk). On the whole, nearly every candidate stuck to the focus of the question (storing wine). Generally, there was a good range of examples provided by candidates, adding substance and interest to their answers. Good candidates were aware and used technical information such as pH, VA limits, SO₂, etc. appropriately along with analysis of impacts.

Weaker answers tended to be descriptive without sufficient technical knowledge of processes, actions and likely timings. Candidates have often read, listened or spoken to winemakers on barrel management, thus have a broad understanding but when it comes to discussing outcomes or timing of an action, it is quickly apparent who hasn't totally grasped the full details. It is a technical question therefore the candidates must show they can use correct technical terminology, figures and timing to add credibility to their answer.

2. What Quality Control (QC) measures should be considered when filling Bag-in-Box compared to traditional glass bottles?

The pass rate was very low for this question, possibly because it required a high level of factual knowledge, with many candidates providing general QC answers rather than focusing on the key word "compared". The question required candidates to consider the different properties of packaging for Bag-in-Box (BiB) and glass, mainly differences in permeability to air and therefore oxygen. They needed to show awareness of the facts that no bag-in-box is impermeable to oxygen ingress, plus the risk of microbial growth and crystal formation causing damage to wine, packaging and potential leakage. Those who had good technical knowledge were able to answer the question well, as they were able to concentrate on these differences specifically, making for clear and logical answers. Those who understood what acceptable levels of FS₀₂ were required to achieve stability in relation to DO₂ and the rate of O₂ ingress generally coped well. Better answers also considered the risk of having high DC₀₂ in BiBs (not many answers addressed this) and implications for shelf life too. Quite a few answers referred to examples of secondary fermentation in BiBs to illustrate the risk of this happening. Better candidates did this in order to discuss how it could have been prevented rather than just a description of what happened. Good answers considered the method of cold stabilisation of wine packed in BiB and noted that the expected reduction of shelf life if using metatartaric acid was unlikely to be a problem as increased O₂ ingress meant the shelf life was lower anyway.

Weaker answers often latched on to the mention of QC measures in the question and produced a non-specific description of all the procedures without debating the salient points of difference between glass and BiB. Key factual information was missing in many cases too. The use of examples was not always carefully thought through. Some candidates used premium wine examples they knew about or had visited, but who were never going to pack their wine in BiBs (Comte Lafon, Louis Latour, Cru Classé claret, etc) which did not contribute anything useful. Few answers dealt with the matter of headspace, and some suggested that bags should be brimful (leaving no room for any expansion in

temperatures warmer than the filling temp). Not many answers considered how to optimise cleanliness of BiB packaging since it can't be sterilised as glass can be.

3. What is the difference between processing aids and ingredients in wine? Discuss with reference to recent changes to EU labelling law for wine and assess the implications of these changes for consumers.

This question was unpopular and very poorly answered by most candidates, with the lowest pass rate on the paper. It should have been a gift for those who had taken note of the new regulations, and it was surprising more had not because it is such a hot topic in the wine industry at present. Knowledge of the legislative changes was often confused, and, with just a few exceptions, there was little attempt at any critical discussion of implications for consumers.

It was obvious from the answers which candidates did know the legislation in sufficient detail. Generally, most essays dealt with the differences between processing aids and ingredients satisfactorily (the basic difference being that processing aids do not remain in the wine and ingredients do, and a number of processing aids are also allergens and must be declared), and specified examples of the main ones. Good answers showed understanding that all allergens now have to be named on the physical label (as well as QR codes, URL links etc.) regardless of whether they are ingredients or processing aids. Good answers also included the requirement for nutritional info. A few candidates recognised that the QR code/web links must not contain any marketing or promotional information which is an important point. EU labelling laws necessarily involve a lot of detail. This was a straightforward question to answer well, but it did require a level of detailed knowledge.

Some answers showed only a superficial understanding of the new laws. Many answers failed to consider the new requirement for certain nutritional information to appear on labels (and for extra information to be accessible via QR codes). Leaving out discussion of either allergens or nutritional info was a major flaw.

Quite a lot of answers conflated ingredient listing with declaration of suitability for vegetarians and vegans, which does not have to be stated. A number complained that the regulations do not require certain fining agents which are not suitable for vegans (e.g. casein, gelatine as these aren't allergens) to appear on the label. Some answers mentioned that as different batches of a given wine and vintage may have had different treatments or nutritional info (e.g. calories, RS) then this will require (expensive) label changes, but did not suggest that the links to QR codes or websites can be updated to reflect latest information, for example as vintages change from one year to the next.

4. Describe the steps a wine technician would take to confirm raised volatile acidity in a bottled red wine sample and identify the source of the problem.

This question had the second-best pass rate. It was a technical question that required candidates to support their answer with correct, factual information and apply this across all aspects of the question. It also required logical thinking about processes and timing of potential risks for formation of raised VA which can occur due to exposure to oxygen, infection with acetic acid bacteria, or

possibly lactic acid bacteria or certain yeasts (especially non-saccharomyces strains), which oxidise alcohol to acetic acid. Knowledge of detection thresholds and legal limits was useful.

Many answers focused just on one part of the answer when discussing potential sources of VA, especially the bottling line, rather than considering the whole life of the red wine from vineyard to bottle. Focusing heavily on the bottling line meant the candidate left out key points from vine to pre-bottling that required discussing to show they had a total grasp on volatile acidity in wine.

Unsurprisingly, not many candidates attempted this question given it was very specific - either you understood volatile acidity, or you didn't. If the candidate did understand volatile acidity in the context of the question, then it should not have been a difficult question to answer.

Some essays were short in length and incomplete, suggesting candidates left this as their last essay and spent too much time on their other questions, leaving insufficient time to fully answer the question. In a number of cases examples were not provided. Perhaps because it appeared to be a theoretical question a number of candidates thought examples were unnecessary, however the opposite is true because relevant examples help to prove to the examiner the candidate does understand the points being made.

Paper four report 2024: Paper chair, James Davis MW

Paper 4 requires candidates to consider and be able to assess the business context of wine. It requires something of a different approach to study compared to papers 1, 2 and 3, not least because there is not an obvious set of specific textbooks to read. We are also living in a different world compared even to 5 years ago and so the financial, commercial and marketing challenges of the international wine industry have changed dramatically.

Candidates should therefore draw from different sources. A critical success factor for paper 4 is being able to demonstrate and use data points to illustrate growth or decline of key wine categories with reference to key markets around the world. Data sources such as Kantar, Nielsen or Circana directly or found through media channels can help demonstrate trends. Similarly, when visiting wineries as part of their studies, candidates should think and ask about ownership structures, sources of capital and whether the business is profitable or not. If not, why not - and does it matter?

Technical knowledge of finance or economics is not needed, but a broad understanding of topics such as profitability, ownership structures, capital investment, demand and supply are important. By applying this knowledge, allied with a strong persuasive structure supported by relevant examples and data points, candidates can easily succeed in paper 4.

1. Evaluate the commercial success of three different styles of rosé wine.

This was the slightly more popular of the two section A questions, perhaps because it appears more straightforward. However, overall it was answered quite poorly. The question was designed to test candidates' knowledge of the differences in various styles of rosé wine from around the world and how these appeal to different consumers and markets.

This was a chance for candidates also to talk about market dynamics and fashions in rosé styles, which could include those that have been successful for a long period as well as those that have been successful more fleetingly or perhaps have not been very successful at all (e.g. Marlborough Sauvignon Blanc rosé).

Many candidates focused on how to sell and promote rosé as opposed to examining the success of different rosé categories. Many essays were superficial and descriptive, but the question invites candidates to evaluate, which required critical thought and assessment backed up by data and appropriate examples.

Surprisingly, a lot of candidates seemed unaware that the rosé category, across many global markets is currently in decline, or often did not have or show accurate data sources to support their arguments.

Candidates needed to show understanding of broad trends over time, not just for the last few years. For example, when was White Zinfandel at its peak success? Equally, candidates should absolutely have known when the Prosecco Rosé DOC category was created as it was so recent.

The best essays included original examples and often incorporated a sparkling and/or fortified example, linking the key themes that made these styles successful, or not.

Describing production techniques was not required although it was relevant for candidates to mention a faster production cycle and cash flow compared to wines that need more ageing. Stronger candidates mentioned interesting points that are perhaps more relevant to the rosé category than others, for example, colour stability and the range of different colours of rosé wine available, from very pale through to much deeper pink, as well as the choice of glass bottle as a way of premising and the colour of the glass.

The question was also an opportunity for candidates to talk about the role of branding that contributes to the success of a rosé style – for example Laurent Perrier Rosé, Blossom Hill, Miraval or celebrity brands such as Kylie Minogue.

It is important that candidates know how to spell the names of producers that they are citing, along with other key terms. Especially for those choosing to submit handwritten papers, make sure you leave enough time for proof reading.

2. Do emerging wine regions need international investment to succeed on the global stage?

Slightly less popular than question 1, this was generally well answered. However, there were few very good or excellent answers and often answers were lacking in some detail, thought and contextual understanding.

The question required candidates to think about the differing ownership structures within the wine industry and what are likely to be the key factors for success. In addition, the question invites candidates to evaluate the role of international investment; and whether this helps the development of an emerging wine region or not.

Candidates could have used different emerging regions from around the world: as this can be subject to interpretation the examiners were flexible in how this was defined. The region could be emerging in relation to viticulture and winemaking; or economic, political and business development.

Some brief explanation of the history of international investment could have been useful to help paint the picture. For example, investment by English families into the Port wine industry and how this developed or investment by German families into Champagne. Other examples could include international investment into Crimea, Oregon, Napa, Lebanon and Israel to name but a few.

The question gave candidates an opportunity to talk through factors such as climate change, improved technology, and viticultural and winemaking experience that may all serve to improve the quality and output within an emerging region. Good papers set such parameters out well for the body of the essay.

Most essays included an ample number of global examples; however some examples were noted as incorrect. A few papers were undone by timing issues and often the papers needed a deeper level of development of the key points.

3. As sales manager for a small, premium winery, outline your strategy to sell to the on-trade.

Overall, this was a popular question. The salient points concerned whether to sell directly or through a distributor, to how many markets and where and how much volume to sell per market.

To show understanding of these points, candidates needed to discuss and show understanding of different routes to market and on-trade structures on a global basis. Strong scripts demonstrated this with examples of distributors and different geographic regions, if not specific cities, around the world. However, some candidates focused too much on a single market with insufficient justification. More successful were answers showing global knowledge, with reference to different countries around the world, supported by relevant examples.

Key to unlocking the question was to define the parameters of what is meant by “small, premium winery”, ideally in terms of cases produced and turnover achieved. The fact that these numbers varied significantly across papers did not matter, although some seemed to stray into “medium size” territory.

The best answers were strategic, rather than listing a series of anecdotes, or ‘brain dumping’ ideas, problems which were evident in weaker scripts. By showing and understanding the strategic aspect to the question, strong candidates successfully identified scope, in terms of market penetration, considering an appropriate distribution solution and associated costs. Other elements such as brand building, training and education were all relevant, as were site visits and a promotional mechanic.

Candidates who resorted to the 5Ps were not necessarily the most imaginative, but often gifted themselves a safety net in terms of covering the territory. Some candidates thought their pre-written “5P’s” essay could be shoehorned into this: a few managed but most scripts read as a bit clunky. All the best answers had strong opening paragraphs, showing that adequate preparation is critical and helps shape an appropriate response.

Finally, as has been mentioned above, some spelling and grammar was shockingly bad: it undermines a script if important and recognised wine region names/villages/producers are misspelled.

4. Examine the profitability of various wine packaging formats from both a production and a retail point of view.

Generally, this question was poorly answered. Candidates needed to show knowledge of the main wine packaging formats, with a clear delineation between production and retail, along with examples. The question invited candidates to discuss various types of packaging formats from traditional to innovative.

The complexity of value/supply chains in the wine industry means that “profitability” is hard to define and isolate: there are many stakeholders involved and variables at play. Profitability should consider both gross margin and capital invested. When candidates visit wineries as part of their studies, I would advise them to think and ask about the immense and often prohibitive levels of capital required.

Strong candidates used wide-ranging examples drawn from different ends of the value spectrum and considered consumer perception of different formats. Good answers touched on the role of the monopolies and this helped show global reach.

There were some wild assertions not backed up with basic data and often a lot of irrelevance. For example, "BiB is first choice for house wines". This might be true in very limited circumstances but is not true of the wider market. Such comments can be highly off-putting and serve to undermine stronger narrative and examples within an essay. Perhaps these assertions might be made due to lack of time. Again, leaving sufficient time to proofread and check your answer is critical.

5. Evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of own-label projects for a medium-sized winery.

This was a popular and well answered question with a high pass rate. There was the potential for candidates to couch the question in the context of a response to global/regional overproduction (and underproduction now in areas such as Cava) and how this might be seen as a strength or a weakness.

The candidates that fared well showed an understanding of the role of own-label and could apply a practical and commercial context as to its strengths and weaknesses.

In some instances, there was a misunderstanding of "own-label". "Own-label" is most usually related to off-trade driven supermarket projects, but this may cover the on-trade also. It could also be a buyer's own brand, or a label registered to a retailer rather than the winery.

Examiners took a pragmatic attitude to the term "medium-sized". The purpose of this was to encourage candidates to focus discussion on wineries for whom the benefits of own label are not necessarily obvious, as opposed to large-scale wineries that are more dedicated to own-label projects. The best essays were well structured with intelligent, balanced discussion showing an overall global market perspective.

6. What are the financial barriers to success for a new wine producer and how can these be overcome?

This question tested real-life, practical knowledge of the challenges faced by a new wine producer. The key words requiring definition and some analysis are "financial" and "success". Success could be defined in different ways, but its framework has to be outlined in some way. Most candidates were able to focus on financial rather than other barriers. These barriers could include those centred on the immediate environment (costs, cash flow, utilities, return on capital, labour shortages/costs/negotiations, tax burden etc.) through to broader challenges (interest rates, lack of support from financial institutions/government in terms of grants, tariffs, subsidies, etc.).

A multi-part question requires discussion around each part. Overall, depth of discussion was lacking much of the time. Some jumped directly into a brand building exercise, with no focus on sourcing and production of the wine. Some papers meandered into topics that were not relevant to the question, or spent too much time on fringe topics that garnered few marks. Generally, good examples were provided, and some displayed a solid level of first-hand knowledge and experience. That said, a couple of papers were completely free from examples. Many papers were written as data dump of

information, lacking critical thought and with too much focus on the financial barriers and too little on how to overcome them.

To show international context, candidates could have demonstrated differences in the ways wineries sell their products and how this impacts cash flow. Wineries in the USA focus on cellar door sales which arguably generates income more quickly compared to a 3-tier distribution system. There was a lot of scope for good answers, even if one or two writers decided to take one example and run with it rather than draw more broadly from different markets. Candidates also needed to consider ways of mitigating barriers, which could include initiatives such as pre-selling wine or leasing rather than buying equipment outright. Candidates with practical experience and knowledge considered ideas such as buying grapes rather than land to drive revenue more quickly and asking third-party wineries to produce or bottle wine.

Paper five report 2024: Paper chair, Ken MacKay MW

General Comments

In general, the examiners felt that many candidates were less prepared for this paper than in previous years. An overall impression of a lower standard in answers was perhaps reflected in the lower pass rate for the paper. However, it is also important to point out that this was compounded by a significant number of incomplete papers, where only one question or, in some cases, no questions at all were attempted. For all of these candidates, it was obviously either impossible or exceptionally challenging to be able to pass the paper.

Paper 5 is about mastery of communication in wine, and requires accurate, clear, balanced and critical answers, supported by relevant examples, displaying good insight into the global world of wine. Unfortunately, the examiners reported that the standard of written English was quite poor this year. Only the minority of essays could be described as well written, let alone excellent, in this regard. Some of the commonest failings are worth highlighting.

Overall, arguments were often poorly structured and rambling, containing irrelevant examples, facts or arguments, or not focused on answering the specific question. The examiners would like to emphasise that candidates must resist the urge to crowbar 'interesting facts' into their answers. If something is not *directly relevant* to answering a specific question, it almost certainly *weakens* the answer if it's included, no matter how dazzling and impressive the information might seem to be.

Furthermore, many papers were answered at a very high level, in broad, simplistic terms, with little in the way of supporting detail or clear, specific examples or evidence. At the same time, candidates frequently took an overly narrow focus in their answers to questions and failed to cover enough of the breadth of different considerations, such as financial impacts, or different global or supply chain perspectives.

Finally, a large number of papers (perhaps the highest in recent years) contained multiple misspelled wine/winery/winemaker names and technical wine terms. This is clearly not something which reflects mastery of wine.

Many of these fundamental essentials have been emphasised in previous examiners' reports, which we would direct any candidates who have an aspiration to pass the exam to review and digest, as they are an enormously helpful source of guidance.

1. 'Great wine is made in the vineyard.' Do you agree?

This was the paper's most popular question, and the examiners felt that candidates should have been very well prepared to answer such a straightforward question. A clear definition of "great wine" at the outset was vital. On the whole, the phrase was quite well defined and addressed; but a significant number of candidates offered very nebulous definitions (or often just implied one) and these answers then lost focus and failed to clearly answer the question. Strong definitions of great wine were precise (not just BLIC-based), but also acknowledged that there are diverse, subtle differences of perspectives on membership of this category, from different producers, businesses and consumers. Only the best answers really delved into what separated great wines from the merely very good. Some candidates set the bar far too low, considering in too much detail the sanitary condition of the grapes, as if that is what really distinguishes great wines from their peers.

At a crude level, the relative importance of natural versus human inputs, in the vineyard and winery, was generally understood. However, it was surprising how many answers failed to appreciate the central importance of 'terroir', as a key aspect to be discussed. Many answers failed to unpick the contribution to greatness of specific vineyards and plots ('terroir'), from the management practices in those vineyards, which made their arguments muddled. Many candidates also thought listing wines made from respected terroirs was somehow sufficient. The answer needed to show *how* terroir and viticulture influenced grapes, in a way that raises quality and imbues the resulting wine with special character.

Vineyard and winery process are not really equivalent in terms of the nature or granularity of their respective contribution to a wine's character, but were mostly treated very simplistically as two sides of the same coin. Disappointingly, the crucial, broader socio-cultural and economic contributions to the perceived greatness of wine - such as history, reputation and critical acclaim, classifications, supply and demand, control of distribution, marketing, and so on - were rarely explored. Overall, the examiners felt that the level of clear and original analysis was very disappointing for paper 5.

Better answers offered a nuanced reframing of the question, arguing that great wine "is born/begins in the vineyard", and contrasted wines whose character is typically attributed to terroir (such as burgundy) with those that owe much of their character to process (for example, sparkling or fortifieds), using telling examples. Stronger answers often also observed that even the latter tend to prize superior vineyard sites, adding another dimension to their arguments. The sophisticated minority broadened the question beyond "vineyard vs. winery" arguments, to argue that a central component of greatness is market perception, and hence that there is a post-production contribution from critics, collectors, marketeers and so on.

2. Could it be argued that recent climate change has been a good thing for wine lovers?

A definition of "recent climate change" was an obvious requirement to answer this essay, along with a clarification from the candidate as to whom they understood "wine lovers" to be. The essay demanded specific knowledge of at least some of the evidence, in terms of statistics and facts, to support recent climate change concerns. The question required candidates to understand that this was not just an essay on viticultural impacts of climate change, but an analysis into whether it had benefited areas across the entire supply chain, and the impact of climate change on winemaking processes, styles,

quality, packaging, logistics and consumer choice. Some insight into financial consequences, and the knock-on effects for consumer pricing, were also a critical part of this essay. Overall, it was essential that answers offered a clear, logical and balanced argument, considering the positive impacts of climate change for wine lovers and also its negative consequences. This was in many ways a good, old fashioned 'pros and cons' answer, which required interesting global examples to support the argument, as well as a strong, clear conclusion.

Poorer answers often did not outline in enough depth what "recent climate change" looked like, many referring to global warming and its impact on vineyards rather than considering a broader perspective, essential for paper 5, of its impact on prices, packaging, style, etc. "Wine lovers" were often not defined at all, when it was necessary to understand to whom the candidate understood this term referred. The main issue for non-passing answers, however, was the lack of a balanced argument. Many answers focused either purely, or mostly, on arguing how recent climate change could be seen to be a good thing, whereas the only way to answer 'could it be argued' was to give equal time to the opposing view. Poorer answers also did not include enough specific facts or examples to pass and ended with weak conclusions, often not answering the question.

Good answers defined key terms from the outset and discussed the topic in a logical way, taking different impacts of climate change and considering their pros and cons across the supply chain, and the multi-dimensional impact of climate change on aspects of grape growing, winemaking, wine style, packaging, logistics and price. Specific, relevant and global examples also lifted these essays, along with more critical thought around the subject. The best answers evidenced superb recall of relevant climate change statistics and factors in well written, thoughtful, clearly structured, balanced essays with relevant, focused and global examples, as well as some consideration of different consumer segments (wine lovers) and impacts on the entire wine production chain.

3. Propose and justify a contemporary definition of 'fine wine' and discuss how perspectives on this may have changed over time.

Obviously, there was no simple 'correct' answer to this question. The term 'fine wine' is used frequently in wine circles, but it is a complex, evolving and necessarily fluid category, which has been interpreted somewhat differently, depending on historical moment and national/individual perspectives. Historically, the term was arguably used more consistently and was certainly less inclusive for most, with membership consisting predominantly of French wines and perhaps other specific famous European regions. To answer this question clearly, it was essential that the candidate proposed a contemporary definition, rather than simply list various opinions of what elements might contribute to making a wine "fine".

Whatever route was chosen for the argument, this seemingly simple question required some basic knowledge of the fine wine trade and its history, and the ability to stake out the boundaries of a definition that could explain why wine X would be called "fine" and wine Y not. Very few answers managed to demonstrate either quality. Naïve or outdated perspectives and shaky logic often rubbed shoulders with some extraordinary factual errors. Such a broad topic offers an almost limitless choice of examples, so why some candidates opted for producers or events with which they were clearly unfamiliar was mystifying. One recurring misconception saw candidates cite Millennials' indifference to fine wine. Sotheby's claim 30% of their wine and spirits clientele in 2022 was under 40,

and fine wine is attracting similar interest to other luxury categories (watches, cars, etc.) among young Americans with high disposable income. The overall decline in alcohol consumption among younger age brackets does not necessarily map onto waning interest at the top end – quite possibly the reverse.

Many answers focused too much on narrow considerations. These included the importance of packaging, which, although it is typically aligned with a wine's status, does not itself make the wine fine. Others focused almost entirely on sustainability and organics, which are also not, in themselves, justifications of "fine wine", although many fine wines are also sustainably produced. A few also presented simplistic arguments regarding 'natural' wine status or price, in isolation, which were also unconvincing. Very few essays focused on the distinction between fine wine and high-quality wine, and whether this line had become blurred.

Passing answers reflected an understanding that "fine wine" developed to differentiate the best wines and justify a wine's value or price to buyers, consumers or collectors. Crucially, they also presented a clear definition, supported by evidence. The handful of good answers addressed more of the semantic and practical points invited by the question. Why (and to whom) is the term useful at all? To what extent does "fine wine" overlap with good wine? Who gets to say whether a wine is fine or not? How have these considerations changed, if at all? These better answers considered diverse 'perspectives' (for example, of collectors, retailers, auctioneers, restaurant owners, sommeliers, writers/critics, different international markets) and multiple change-drivers, such as the shifting influences of classifications, influencers (of all kinds), long-term investment potential, age-worthiness, routes to market, and historical reputation (of both producer and region), as well as perceived rarity. Relevant parallels with the art market, members' clubs, the evolution of 'fine dining', or socioeconomic categories, were also helpful supporting insights.

4. How and why should governments influence wine consumption?

Three key words should have been underlined before attempting this question. "How" and "why" are the most obvious and answers needed to balance both considerations, using global examples. However, it was also essential that the answer addressed what governments "should" do, to influence wine consumption.

Governments can and do exert a substantial influence over how, where, when - and at what price - wine can be consumed. A review of some of the main tools of influence a government has was essential. These include: taxes, import quotas, export subsidies and financial support, public campaigns, minimum pricing, age restriction, labelling requirements, advertising restrictions, as well as complex licensing and permit schemes. Linked to this was the necessary consideration of the many motivations governments have to influence consumption, which include: reducing the harmful effects of alcohol on both individual and public health and safety; consumer protection through clear and standardised labelling and packaging regulations; supporting the local wine industry on domestic and export markets; protection of minors and vulnerable groups; preserving culturally important traditions and tourism; and regulating commerce.

A common mistake was to address only half of the question - both the "how" or "why" needed to be answered, but many answers focused on one or the other. Poorer answers also lacked appropriate

realism and balance, by offering somewhat blinkered criticism of the WHO's position on 'safe' doses of alcohol and naively questioning the compelling scientific evidence for the negative consequences of alcohol consumption. Similarly, poorer answers lacked appropriate insight into different global markets and failed to consider the many different types of regulations/policies that governments could implement. Weaker answers were mostly entirely descriptive, rather than evaluative, mentioning something such as the Loi Évin, for instance, but then failing to elaborate whether it was a sensible approach or whether other countries should adopt similar restrictions. The 'should' part of the question required a clear opinion and many candidates failed to provide any answers.

Passing answers avoided these pitfalls and managed to answer all elements of the question, as well as weigh the government's responsibility to protect the health and welfare of its citizens (with specific mention of things like cancer, liver disease, alcoholism and mental health problems) against their, potentially conflicting, responsibility of promoting responsible wine consumption, to support the wine industry's important cultural and economic contributions to society. Specific global examples, such as comparative tax rates, were important to support the 'how' part of the evidence. Better passes engaged with the question as to whether wine should be a 'special case' amongst alcohol products, due to its particular balance of positive and negative socio-economic impacts. The best answers wove in a truly global, critical and balanced view – with diverse, relevant examples from around the world – which reflected an understanding of how and why governments influence wine consumption, and clearly justified opinions on when it should, or should not, interfere.

5. How important is the concept of a defined wine region?

This was a popular question, with many successful answers, but also a large number of poorer answers. In answering this question, candidates needed to be clear in their definition of a "defined wine region", before clearly weighing up the importance of this concept in a logical, well-evidenced discussion. Crucially, candidates needed to grasp that this question was not an abstract one and, therefore, it required a systematic consideration of to whom the concept of a defined wine region might be important, across all parts of the global wine supply chain.

Many poorer answers failed to give any clear definition of the scope of "defined wine regions", which hampered their ability to clearly delve into their importance, in all their various forms. Weaker answers also failed to present their argument in any logical structure or show any balanced, critical thinking around the topic, often being very 'top line' or 'stream of consciousness' in style. Many of these answers used very generic examples, only referring to entire regions throughout the whole essay rather than focusing in on more specific and valuable illustrations of their points. The majority of candidates failed to reference Champagne or the CIVC which felt like a major omission, given its importance and dominance of its category, supported by strong protectionism. Overall, there was a disappointing level of understanding in many answers about the importance and value of wine regions to producers – based on terroir and other factors, and how these elements define, support and protect them – and many candidates simply addressed the topic from a consumer marketing perspective.

Passing answers were able to demonstrate a clear, well-structured argument, and provided more precise examples (whether producer, retailer, wholesaler etc.), that lifted their answers. The best answers examined the question with some historical context, considering the reasons for defining

wine regions and how their relevance might have evolved. They also explored the issue in greater depth, for example: referencing retail outlets that merchandise their wines by style, rather than region; exploring brands and varietals, and the importance of other cues on wine labels, to different demographics, markets and producers; considering cross-regional blends; or even drawing useful illustrative comparisons with other consumer products, to highlight some of the particular differences of the wine category.